

Minimalist Brand Research

Minimalist Brand, Advertising & Claims Research Notes

Research reviewed: September 2026

Market focus: India

1. Research objective

I reviewed publicly available material to understand how Minimalist communicates its products, what appears consistent across its brand and advertising, how comparable skincare brands communicate, and what claims-related constraints matter for skincare advertising in India.

The research covered Minimalist's official brand and product pages, website search metadata, founder interviews, examples of Minimalist paid advertising, ads from comparable skincare and wellness brands, and relevant Indian advertising and cosmetics guidance.

My objective was to separate **what the brand actually says and does** from assumptions about what a "science-led skincare brand" should look or sound like.

2. What Minimalist appears to stand for

Minimalist consistently positions itself around **science, efficacy, transparency, simplicity and accessibility**.

On its official brand pages, Minimalist describes itself as a high-performance skincare brand rooted in scientific research and talks about creating skincare that is simple, honest and backed by science. Transparency is not limited to listing ingredients; the brand explicitly connects it with clear communication as well.

Its Values content goes further by highlighting information such as ingredient concentrations, ingredient sources, pH, expected results and expected time to results. The same material criticises inaccurate advice, incorrect claims and fear-mongering in the skincare category.

My interpretation

Minimalist's identity is not simply about "minimal" visual design.

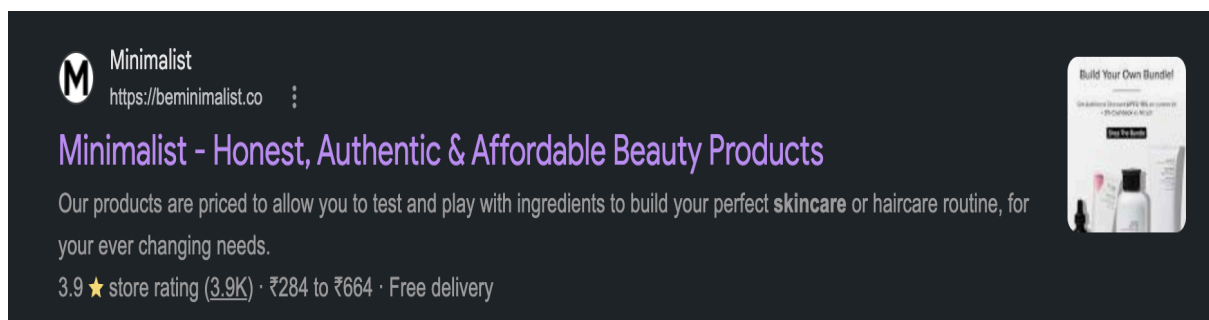
A better description is:

Specific, evidence-oriented skincare communication that helps a customer understand what is in a product, what it is intended to do and why they should believe it.

This distinction matters because the brand does make strong benefit and efficacy statements; it is not a brand that avoids claims altogether.

3. Search and discovery positioning

I also looked at how the brand presents itself through search metadata.



Meta title

Minimalist - Honest, Authentic & Affordable Beauty Products

This adds two useful ideas to the positioning already visible on the brand pages: **authenticity** and **affordability**.

Meta description

Our products are priced to allow you to test and play with ingredients to build your perfect skincare or haircare routine, for your ever changing needs.

This suggests that Minimalist is not communicating science as something inaccessible or overly clinical. The brand also wants customers to feel able to **understand ingredients, experiment responsibly and build a routine around their own needs**.

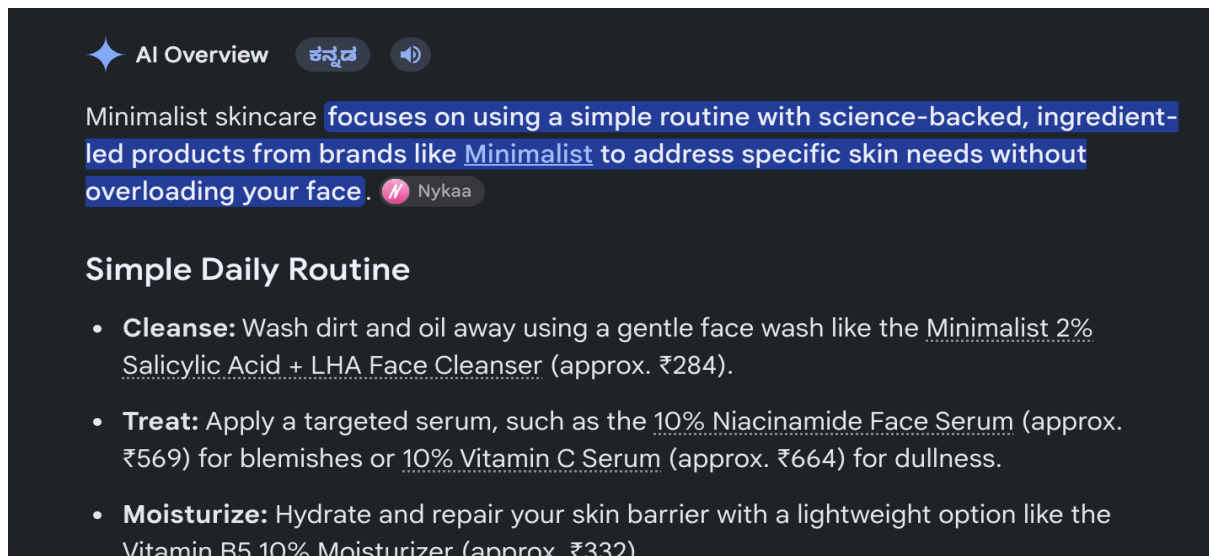
Combined with the product-page research, the communication model appears to be:

ingredient understanding → specific need → appropriate product → routine

rather than simply:

beauty aspiration → product purchase

Google AI Overview description



The search AI overview described Minimalist skincare around a simple routine using science-backed, ingredient-led products to address specific skin needs without overloading the skin.

I would treat this differently from the metadata above.

The AI overview is **not Minimalist-authored content**, so it should not be used as a source of brand rules. It is useful only as an external signal of how search systems currently interpret the brand.

Interestingly, the interpretation is directionally consistent with Minimalist's own messaging around:

- simplicity
- science
- ingredients
- specific skin concerns
- avoiding unnecessary complexity

This becomes particularly relevant when thinking about **AEO/search perception**, but I would not treat it as authoritative brand evidence.

4. What I observed on Minimalist product pages

I reviewed product pages including **Salicylic Acid 2% Face Serum** and **Light Fluid SPF 50 Sunscreen**.

A recurring pattern is that the **ingredient or functional specification is part of the product identity itself**.

The Salicylic Acid page leads with the active concentration and uses direct benefit language around acne, blackheads and excess oil. It also provides information including pH, skin type, concern, age suitability and usage.

Importantly, Minimalist also publishes quantitative claims. The same page reports consumer-study outcomes over defined periods.

The sunscreen page similarly foregrounds SPF and PA protection while providing product specifications, ingredients, suitability and usage information.

Communication pattern I observed

A useful approximation is:

Ingredient / specification → mechanism or reason → consumer benefit → evidence or supporting detail

This is different from generic beauty advertising built mainly around statements such as:

“Reveal flawless beauty.”

Minimalist tends to give the customer a more concrete reason to believe the promised benefit.

Important finding

It would be easy to assume:

“Minimalist is science-led, therefore strong marketing claims are off-brand.”

The public product pages suggest otherwise.

A more accurate interpretation is:

Strong claims can fit the brand when the strength and specificity of the claim are supported by corresponding evidence.

That distinction is more useful than simply classifying copy as “strong” or “weak”.

5. What “transparency” appears to mean

Founder interviews reinforced the same idea.

Mohit Yadav has described transparency as extending beyond an ingredient list to information such as ingredient concentration, supplier information, what a product does, supporting results and who a product is appropriate for. He has also discussed whether sufficient research exists behind product claims.

I treated founder interviews as context rather than formal brand policy because they may pre-date current formulations, campaigns or internal standards. Current first-party product information should carry more weight if there is any conflict.

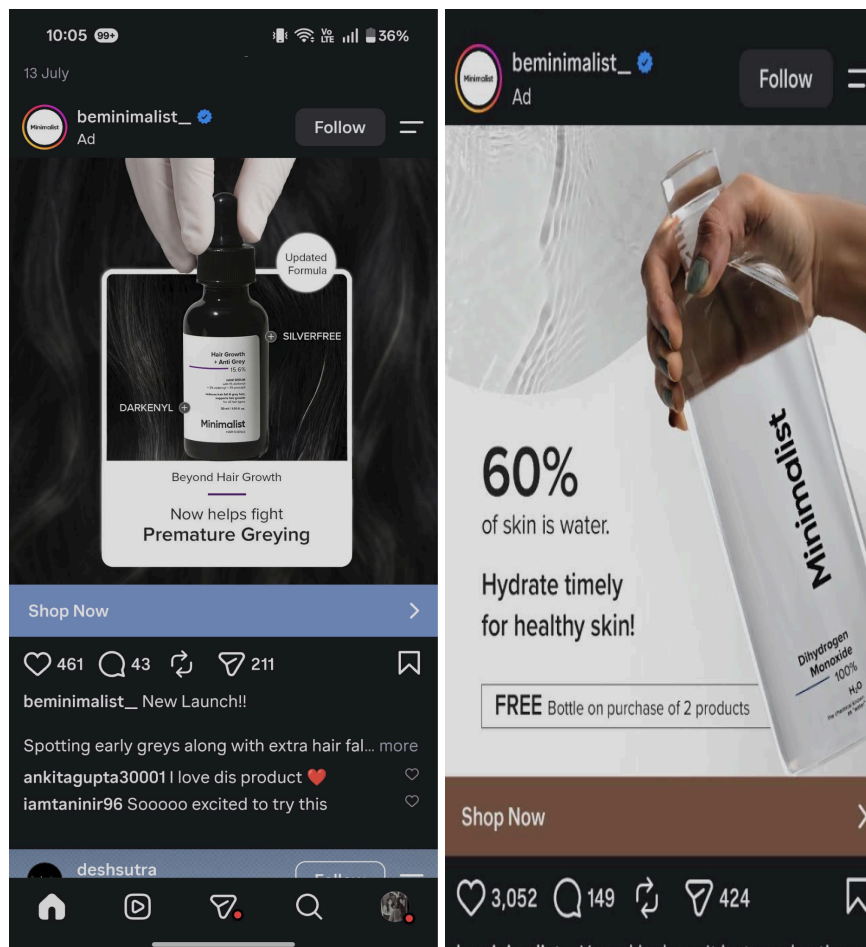
Research takeaway

For Minimalist, transparency appears to mean something closer to:

Tell customers what is in the product, what it is intended to do, who it is for and what supports the statement being made.

That is broader than simply publishing an ingredient list.

6. Observations from Minimalist paid ads



I reviewed two Minimalist Instagram ad examples.

One creative focuses on a hair product and communicates an updated formula and a premature-greying benefit. The second uses the statement “**60% of skin is water**” as the opening hook before moving into a hydration message. Both creatives include a purchase CTA, and one also includes a promotional offer.

Several things stood out.

Product remains prominent

Both examples keep the actual product highly visible rather than allowing lifestyle imagery to become the entire story.

There is no single rigid visual treatment

One creative is dark, technical and tightly composed. The other is light, open and more lifestyle-oriented.

Therefore I would not derive a rule such as:

“Minimalist ads must always have a white clinical background.”

The observed ads do not support that conclusion.

Numbers can be used as hooks

The hydration creative demonstrates that a number or scientific fact can lead an advertisement.

This means numbers should not automatically be considered off-brand. The more important questions are:

Where did this number come from?

and

Is the way it is being used accurate and supportable?

Promotional communication is acceptable

The examples include Shop Now messaging and a promotional offer.

So “science-first” does not mean “non-commercial”.

Messages remain concrete

Even though the visual styles differ, the ads communicate a specific product or benefit proposition rather than relying only on broad beauty, confidence or aspiration messaging.

7. Category advertising comparison

plumgoodness Ad Follow

2x hydration. bottled.

lightweight, hydrating moisturizer. clinically proven.



plum
— we have chemistry™ —

Shop Now

29 1 6

ozivanutrition Ad Follow

Amazon's Choice

Hydrate Your Skin from Within! *The Better Way!*

Improves skin moisture by **33%** Boosts skin elasticity by **15%**
Reduces moisture loss by **26%**



BUY NOW
GRAB AND GONE!

Shop Now

28 6

phdbeautyindia Ad Follow



Powered by 2% Salicylic Acid + Niacinamide

Reduces Acne & Excess Oil

Shop Now

mywishcare Ad Follow

WishCare

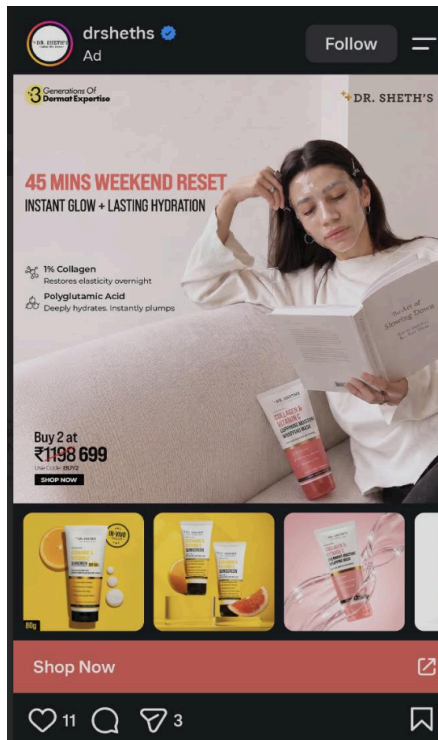
The only 3 SPF50+ essentials you need that actually works

Combo at ₹1297 **₹899**



Shop Now

25 2



I also reviewed ads from brands including Plum, OZiva, PhD Beauty, WishCare, World of Asaya, Dr Sheth's and Be Bodywise.

Across this sample, I observed frequent use of percentages, ingredient concentrations, ratings, SPF values, prices, bundles, benefit statements, "clinically proven" language and direct purchase CTAs. The actual product pack was visible in every example reviewed.

Some examples illustrate the range of approaches:

Brand	Primary communication device
Plum	“2x hydration” as the hero claim
OZiva	Multiple quantified benefit statements
PhD Beauty	Active ingredient + concentration
WishCare	Product proposition + bundle pricing
World of Asaya	Offer-led creative
Dr Sheth’s	Routine/lifestyle + promotion
Be Bodywise	Product rating as hero message

What this comparison tells me

The skincare and wellness category already uses scientific vocabulary, percentages, actives and performance claims heavily.

Therefore:

ingredient + percentage + clinical-looking design

by itself is not enough to make an ad recognisably Minimalist.

The brand differentiation appears more likely to come from the combination of:

specificity + transparency + product connection + understandable science + appropriate substantiation + restrained communication

The comparator sample is small, so I would not use it to conclude that a particular advertising technique performs better or that a particular claim is compliant.

8. Brand tone vs brand language vs claims safety

The research made one distinction particularly important.

These are three different questions.

Policy and claims

Can we responsibly make this statement?

Example:

“Clinically proven to eliminate acne in seven days.”

The wording may sound scientific, but without appropriate evidence the issue is claim substantiation.

Brand tone

Does this feel like how Minimalist communicates?

Example:

“Destroy your ugly acne and get flawless skin NOW!”

Even without a difficult factual claim, the framing feels inconsistent with the brand's educational and non-fear-based positioning.

Brand language

Is the product being described with the degree of specificity and vocabulary Minimalist typically uses?

Example:

“A magical serum for perfect skin.”

This could be legally harmless but still weak brand language because it loses the product's ingredient-led specificity.

Keeping these dimensions separate appears important. A creative can be **compliant but off-brand**, or **on-brand in tone but unsafe because a claim is unsupported**.

9. India advertising and claims context

I reviewed the major India-level sources relevant to cosmetics advertising.

Cosmetics Rules, 2020

Rule 36 states that a cosmetic should not claim or convey an idea that is false or misleading to the intended user.

Consumer Protection and misleading advertising

The Consumer Protection framework covers false descriptions, false guarantees, representations likely to mislead consumers and deliberate concealment of important information.

The CCPA advertising guidelines also address exaggeration of scientific validity, usefulness, capability and performance, and the presentation of disputed scientific claims as universally accepted.

ASCI

The ASCI Code states that objectively ascertainable descriptions and claims should be capable of substantiation.

Where an advertisement explicitly relies on independent research, the source and date should be indicated. The Code also considers misleading communication through implication, omission, ambiguity and exaggeration.

Practical interpretation

Claims review should therefore look beyond obvious factual falsehoods.

Relevant risk areas include unsupported efficacy claims, exaggerated results, incorrect ingredient or concentration information, absolute claims where evidence is conditional, misleading implication or omission, unsupported “clinically proven” statements, unsupported superiority claims, and treatment or cure language that may go beyond an appropriate cosmetic benefit.

A statement **sounding scientific** is not evidence that it is substantiated.

10. Key research conclusions

The research currently leads me to seven main conclusions.

Minimalist is evidence-forward rather than claim-averse. The brand itself uses direct benefit and quantified claims, so strong claims should not automatically be rejected.

Ingredient specificity is central to the language. Actives, concentrations, functional specifications and product details are prominent across the product experience.

Science is communicated for consumers, not scientists. The brand combines technical information with understandable benefit language.

The product should remain strongly connected to the message. Paid examples keep the product visible and communicate a concrete reason to consider it.

Promotional messaging can still fit the brand. Offers and direct purchase CTAs coexist with science-led product communication.

Brand fit and claims of safety are separate problems. An advertisement can sound exactly like Minimalist while still containing an unsupported claim.

Most importantly:

Claim strength should not exceed evidence strength.

This is the strongest principle I took away from the research.

For example:

Known product fact

“2% Salicylic Acid”

can be reproduced accurately.

A documented consumer-study result may potentially support a quantified outcome if the wording and context are preserved.

But that evidence should not be transformed into something materially stronger such as:

“Guaranteed to eliminate acne in four weeks.”

The underlying product may be the same, but the claim is not.

11. Research limitations and open questions

This research uses public information and cannot recreate Minimalist's internal brand or legal approval process.

I did not have access to Minimalist's internal brand book, SKU-level approved claim library, substantiation files, accepted/rejected creative history, reviewer comments or campaign performance data. Public pages can also change over time.

Several questions would therefore require internal confirmation before these observations could become a production approval standard:

- whether product-page wording is automatically approved for reuse in paid advertising;
- which qualifiers need to accompany study or clinical results;
- what evidence supports each approved efficacy claim;
- where cosmetic benefit language crosses into treatment or cure language;
- which claims always require legal review;
- how approved wording differs across markets.

The public product page can tell us **what the brand has said**, but not necessarily **why that exact wording was approved or under which conditions it can safely be reused**.

Sources reviewed

Minimalist first-party sources: Minimalist About, Values, Salicylic Acid 2% Face Serum and Light Fluid SPF 50 product pages, plus Minimalist website metadata/search presentation.

Founder/company context: published interviews with co-founder Mohit Yadav including Amazon India, YourStory and Moneycontrol.

Advertising research: Minimalist Instagram ad examples and comparator ads from Plum, OZiva, PhD Beauty, WishCare, World of Asaya, Dr Sheth's and Be Bodywise.

India regulatory/self-regulatory sources: Cosmetics Rules 2020, Consumer Protection Act 2019, CCPA Guidelines for Prevention of Misleading Advertisements 2022 and the ASCI Code.

Platform research: relevant Google Ads misrepresentation and health-related advertising guidance.

Search interpretation: current AI Overview observed during research; treated as a third-party/search-system interpretation rather than first-party brand evidence.

Product Decision Note

Product Decision Note

Brand / claims approach

I looked at Minimalist's own website and product pages, a few founder interviews, some of their ads, competitor ads, and the India advertising / claims guidance.

A few things stood out to me:

- Minimalist is science-led, but that does not mean it avoids strong claims. It does use quantified and efficacy claims when there is supporting information.
- Ingredients and concentrations are a big part of how the brand communicates. I want to preserve those exactly rather than let the model paraphrase them loosely.
- The tone is educational and direct, but still consumer-friendly. It should not sound like a research paper.
- I would avoid fear-based language, exaggerated outcomes, unsupported “#1” type claims, guaranteed results, or cure-like claims.
- I am treating brand fit and compliance as separate checks. Something can sound like a Minimalist and still make a risky claim.

The principle I am using for the prototype is:

“Claim strength should not be higher than the evidence available to support it.”

For that reason, I am also not treating every claim on a public product page as automatically approved for paid advertising. I only know that Minimalist has published it, not what internal approval or substantiation sits behind it.

Scope considered for V1

I intentionally kept the first version narrow:

- **Targeting only the India market** - this is the regulatory context I researched. I did not want to imply support for international compliance without evidence.
- **Only targeting Meta Ad** - enough to test the generation + review workflow without spending time on format variations for other ad platforms like Google Ads or anything else
- **Will use Actual product image from the product page** - avoids fabricating or altering the representation of a real skincare product.
- **One generated creative format** - the goal is to test whether the system can produce one usable, defensible output, not maximize creative volume.
- **Export not allowed before the automated review** - this addresses the higher-cost failure: letting a misleading or unsupported claim go live.

I deliberately did not build multiple placements, generated product imagery, direct publishing to Meta/Google, international compliance, collaboration workflows or campaign analytics.

Product URL remains the only required input; campaign objective and audience are optional. Price, offers and ratings are extracted when available but treated as dynamic source facts rather than permanent product attributes.

Brand Rules

Brand Rules:

ID	Category	Rule	Rationale	Violation	Uncertainty
CLAIM-001	Claims	Product facts must match source	Minimalist's positioning relies heavily on transparency and precise product information. Wrong ingredient, concentration, SPF, or formulation data is a direct trust failure.	BLOCK	REVIEW
CLAIM-002	Claims	Do not invent product benefits	The model should not use general skincare knowledge as evidence for a specific product. Benefits should come from the supplied product source.	BLOCK	REVIEW
CLAIM-003	Claims	Claim strength must not exceed evidence strength	Minimalist does use strong and quantified claims, but the wording should not become stronger than the evidence supporting it.	BLOCK	REVIEW
CLAIM-004	Claims	Absolute or guaranteed outcomes require exceptional evidence	Terms such as "guaranteed", "100%", "permanent", or "completely eliminates" create very strong expectations and are risky without evidence supporting that exact promise.	BLOCK	BLOCK
CLAIM-005	Claims	Clinical/scientific proof claims require substantiation	Phrases such as "clinically proven" imply a specific level of evidence. They should only be used when the available source supports that characterization.	BLOCK	REVIEW

CLAIM-006	Claims	Quantified efficacy claims require evidence and qualifiers	Percentages, multiples, and time-bound results appear objective and measurable. They need traceable evidence and relevant context such as study duration or subject population.	BLOCK	REVIEW
CLAIM-007	Claims	Ranking and superiority claims require evidence	Claims such as “#1”, “best”, or “most recommended” compare the product against alternatives and therefore require appropriate substantiation.	BLOCK	REVIEW
CLAIM-008	Claims	Avoid unsupported treatment or cure language	Cosmetic benefit language can become materially different when converted into claims about treating, preventing, or curing a medical condition.	BLOCK	REVIEW
CLAIM-009	Claims	Material qualifiers must not be removed	Removing context such as “of subjects”, “after 4 weeks”, or the testing method can materially change what an evidence-backed statement means.	BLOCK	REVIEW
TONE-001	Tone	Science-led but consumer-friendly	Minimalist communicates science and ingredients clearly, but its consumer communication is not written like an academic paper.	WARN	WARN
TONE-002	Tone	Avoid fear, shame, and insecurity framing	Minimalist explicitly positions itself against fear-mongering and misleading category communication. Product problems should be addressed without exploiting insecurity.	WARN	WARN

TONE-003	Tone	Avoid vague hyperbole	Generic beauty terms such as “miracle”, “flawless”, or “perfect skin” replace the specific, product-led reasoning that is characteristic of Minimalist.	WARN	WARN
TONE-004	Tone	Promotional messaging is allowed	The paid-ad examples show that offers, launches, and purchase CTAs can coexist with Minimalist’s science-led communication. Promotion alone is not off-brand.	PASS	PASS
LANG-001	Language	Prefer specific product language	Minimalist frequently communicates through exact actives, concentrations, concerns, and benefits instead of generic beauty terminology.	WARN	WARN
LANG-002	Language	Preserve exact ingredient and concentration terminology	Ingredient specificity is central to the brand’s transparency. Replacing precise information with vague language reduces accuracy; changing the value creates a factual error.	BLOCK	REVIEW
LANG-003	Language	Connect the benefit clearly to the product	The reviewed ads keep the product and a concrete product/benefit message central rather than relying only on lifestyle aspiration.	WARN	WARN
LANG-004	Language	Preserve evidence qualifiers	Terms such as study duration, subjects, testing method, or “independently tested” provide important context and should remain when they affect interpretation of the claim.	BLOCK	REVIEW

SYSTEM-001	System	If evidence cannot be verified, escalate rather than guess	The scorer should distinguish between “this is wrong” and “I do not have enough evidence to know.” Uncertainty should trigger human review rather than a confident PASS.	REVIEW	REVIEW
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